



Synchronisation is done based on the date the file was last modified. Say you created a file in offline mode, named 'somefile.txt,' on May 13, 2004, which was not accessed thereafter. Say another user created a file with the same name in the target folder on the desktop on May 16. If you plug your laptop into the network after this, the file on the desktop replaces the one on your laptop.

The Synchronization Manager

Access the Synchronization Manager by going to **Start > All Programs > Accessories > Synchronize**, or just enter 'mobsync' in the Run dialog box. Here, you'll see a number of network drives, as well as Offline Web pages to be synchronised. Select an item and click Setup. There are three

tabs where you can specify when to synchronise. The Logon/Logoff tab lets you decide about synchronising while logging on or off. Use the On Idle tab for synchronising when the computer is not in use. In the Schedule tab, set the time at which synchronisation should start automatically.

The third-party way

Third-party software such as Second Copy (www.centered.com), Folder Match (www.folder-match.com), etc., also help you orchestrate harmony between your laptop and desktop PC. They also throw in some nifty features such as mass file renamers and duplicate file finders.

With synchronisation, you can say goodbye to those backbreaking data transfer days.

Be sure to look at this before you get a laptop!



BATTERY USAGE: Be cautious, as several manufacturers indicate the battery usage time at the lowest possible power settings.

LEGAL SOFTWARE: Make sure your laptop comes with legal software. Some vendors who assemble or sell laptops may not provide you with legal copies of the software. Verify that the software that comes with your laptop is on an original CD, and has a software licence or registration number.

UPGRADABILITY: This may not occur to you when you purchase a laptop, but it's important all the same. Here are some options to look for when upgrading your laptop—the RAM, the CPU, the hard drive, etc. Are the upgrades something you can do yourself, or do they require visits to a service centre?

LOCATION: Make sure you can easily return the laptop to the dealer if it proves unsatisfactory. Also check if the dealer can service your laptop. If he can't, where's the nearest place your laptop can be serviced?

HARD DRIVE: Capacities range from 6 GB to 50 GB. Most users should find 12 to 20 GB enough. In any case, you won't save much

by buying a smaller capacity drive, and will pay a lot more for a larger drive than the one bundled.

PORTS: Most peripheral devices connect to a USB port; make sure there are at least two USB ports. You will also need parallel, serial, and PS/2 (for keyboards and mice) ports.

SIZE AND WEIGHT: Weights range from 1.5 to 4 Kgs, and thicknesses could be as little as 1 inch. Many laptops offer large screens and can work as desktop replacements. The larger the screen, the more bulky your laptop becomes. External power supplies and peripherals can add considerably to the weight. Lightweight portables can become as heavy as regular laptops when you add up the weights of all of the components.

DISPLAY: This will require a compromise if you decide on an ultra-portable model. Most displays now support resolutions of 1024 x 768 pixels, and a 14-inch notebook display is larger than most 15-inch desktop CRTs.

PROCESSOR: The Pentium III M, Pentium 4 M and Athlon mobile processors are available for the laptop segment.